upGrad GSP: The Brief, Explained Simply

Oct 25, 2026 · @Designer Nesil Noble

GSP helps local agencies send students to universities abroad, and earns a commission when a student enrols. GSP 3.0 is the rebuilt platform, going live on 15 December 2026, and this doc explains what we need to design for it.

Everything here comes from the GSP 3.0 Designer Brief (24 Oct 2026), rewritten in plain words. Sections 8 and 9 also include my own reading: anything not stated in the brief is marked as **my view**.

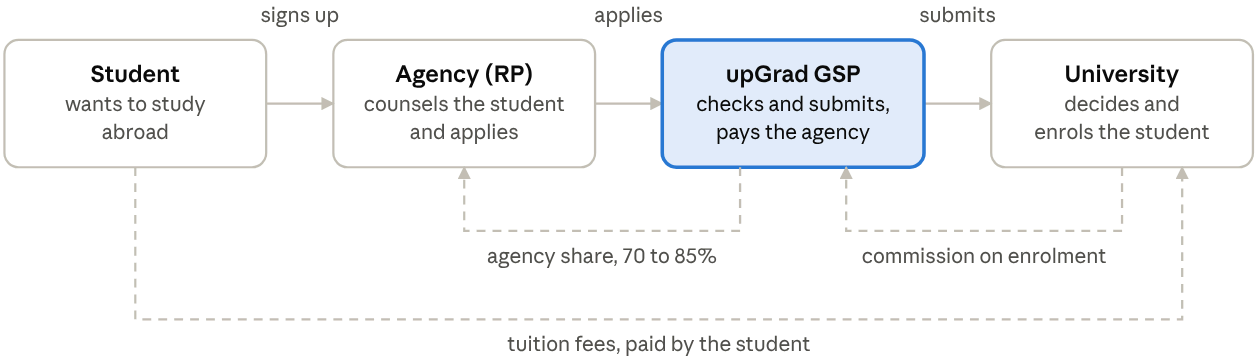
1. The business in simple words

GSP is a middleman between agencies and universities: it earns only when a student actually enrols, and passes most of that money to the agency.

Here is the whole business as a story:

1. A student in India, Vietnam, Bangladesh, Nepal or another country wants to study abroad.
2. They go to a local agency, called a **recruitment partner (RP)**. A counsellor at the agency helps them.
3. The counsellor uses GSP to find a course in Australia, the UK, Canada, the USA, New Zealand, Ireland or Malaysia, and applies through GSP.
4. GSP has agreements with the universities. Its Admissions team checks the documents and submits the application to the university.
5. The university decides. The student accepts the offer, pays a deposit, gets a visa and joins.
6. Once the student has enrolled, the university pays GSP a **commission**. GSP keeps a part and pays the agency its share, usually 70 to 85%.

GSP earns only when a student enrols, and passes most of it on



how the business works · application and money

Solid arrows carry the application; dashed arrows carry the money.

The student pays fees to the university, never to GSP. GSP's money comes only from university commissions.

Scale: about 50,000 applications a year, handled by a small Admissions team in each region. That is why the goal is: the system does the routine work, and people only handle exceptions.

The three questions every agency screen must answer:

1. Where is my application, and who has it right now?
2. What do I need to do?
3. What will I earn, and when?

2. Who the business serves

Seven groups take part in the business, but only two of them sign in to GSP: agencies and GSP's own staff.

Who	Who they are, simply	What they want	Signs in to GSP?
Student	Someone who wants to study abroad	The right course, an offer, a visa	No. The agency works for them (a student can fill their own profile through a link)

Who	Who they are, simply	What they want	Signs in to GSP?
Recruitment partner (RP)	A local agency that counsels students and applies for them	Fast offers, less paperwork, commission paid on time	**Yes, the main users**
Master Partner (MP)	A bigger agency that brings smaller agencies under it and gets paid for them	Visibility of its agencies and their commission	Out of scope for now
Institution partner (IP)	The party GSP signs a commission agreement with: one university, a university group, or an aggregator platform covering 20 to 100+ universities	Qualified students who enrol	No
University	Where the student actually studies	Good applications, sent the way it prefers	No. Reached through its own portal, StudyLink or email
GSP (upGrad) teams	Sales, agency checks, admissions, university set-up, course data, finance	Less manual work, clear queues	**Yes**
Government	Decides the student's visa	A complete visa application	No

3. What the product is

GSP is one web platform with two faces: a portal for agencies, and a workspace for GSP's internal teams. Both use the same layout, with a left sidebar whose menu changes by role.

- **Agency portal:** Home, Applications, Students, Find courses, Earnings, Profile (business and bank details, documents, team and branches).

- **GSP workspace:** each team gets its own menu. Admissions sees My queues, the IP team sees Institution partners, Universities and Courses, BAP sees Agencies, and so on.

The one rule behind the whole product: **people act** (upload, approve, send), **and the system moves the status.** Nobody creates tasks or tickets. Every record has a status, every status has one owner, and acting on a record moves it forward.

The main building blocks, in simple words:

- **University side** (set up by GSP), each level holding many of the next: Institution partner → University → Campus → Course → Intake (a start date, e.g. Feb 2027).
- **Agency side** (set up by the agency): Agency → Branches and team → Students.
- **Application** = one student applying to one course intake. A student can have one **primary** application and some **additional** ones as backups, which start only if the primary fails.
- **Commission lines** are created once a student enrols: first what the university owes GSP, then what GSP owes the agency.

4. What the product is used for

The product runs four journeys: an agency joining, a university going live, a student's application, and the commission being paid.

4.1 An agency joins

1. The agency fills one short sign-up form (name, business, country, email code). It can search courses straight away.
2. It uploads proof that it is a real business (in India: business registration, PAN card, GST certificate, signed partner agreement).
3. GSP's BAP team checks the documents. They can send them back for fixing, approve, or reject.
4. Once approved, the agency is **Activated** and can add students and apply.
5. Once it signs the agreement, it starts earning commission. BAP can later mark it dormant or suspended (search only).

If documents aren't in after 3 days, the agency's GSP sales contact (BDM) is asked to call.

4.2 A university goes live

1. The IP team uploads the signed agreement. **AI reads it and drafts the records.** People only confirm the fields AI wasn't sure about.
2. Three set-up checklists run side by side: Finance sets commission rules; the IP team sets the profile, campuses, who can apply and how to submit; bots and the Data team load courses.
3. The university becomes **Active** and its courses appear in search.
4. 60 days before the agreement ends, it is flagged for renewal. If it lapses, it leaves search, but live applications carry on.

4.3 A student's application, from search to enrolment

Eight stages. At every moment the application sits with exactly one party, and the agency sees who in plain words.

Stage	What the agency sees	Who has it
1. New	Waiting for your documents	Agency
2. Pre-Screening	GSP is checking the documents	GSP (or agency, for a re-upload)
3. Application	GSP is submitting to the university	GSP
4. Offer	With the university for a decision	University (or agency, if it asks for more)
5. Verification	Conditional offer: send the conditions; GSP checks finances	Agency, GSP, university
6. Acceptance	Final offer: pay the deposit; waiting for the enrolment document	Agency, then university
7. Visa	Lodge the visa; waiting for the decision	Agency, then government
8. Enrolled	Enrolled	Done

Any stage can end early: Withdrawn, Deferred, Rejected, Refused, Not eligible, or Did not join. The stages are the same for every country; only the wording changes (for example, the enrolment document is a CoE in Australia, CAS in the UK, I-20 in the USA, LOA in Canada).

4.4 Commission gets paid

1. The student enrols and passes the **census date** (the date after which they count as enrolled).
2. The system works out what the university owes GSP, from the agreement.
3. Finance approves the invoice, and the university pays.
4. The system works out the agency's share and sends a **weekly statement and payment**. At year end, tier top-ups are paid if the agency enrolled enough students.

The agency never makes a claim or raises an invoice. It just sees each line move through: Expected → Confirmed → Invoiced → Paid (or Clawed back).

Supporting everything

- **Course search and eligibility:** find courses and see if the student qualifies.
- **Documents:** upload once, reuse everywhere.
- **Chat and notifications:** replace phone calls and email chains.

5. Who uses the product

Twelve roles sign in: three on the agency side and nine inside GSP (a Master Partner role comes later). Each person has exactly one role and sees only what that role allows. A link to something outside their scope shows "not found", never "no permission".

Agency side

Role	Sees	Does
Agency admin (owner)	Everything in the agency, all branches	Manages branches, team, students, applications, earnings, agency profile and agreement
Branch admin (branch manager)	All students and applications in their branch	Applies, uploads, chats; invites counsellors to the branch
Counsellor	Only their own students and applications	Applies, uploads, chats
Master Partner admin (later)	Its mapped agencies, their applications and commission	Views; receives commission and pays its agencies

GSP side

Role	Covers	What they do in the product
BDM (recruitment manager)	Their agencies	Brings in and looks after agencies; sees their work (read-only); alerted when an agency is stuck
Recruitment head	A sales region	Everything their BDMs see; assigns agencies to BDMs
BAP (agency checks)	Global	Verifies new agencies' documents; activates, marks dormant or suspends
Admissions	One or more regions	Works the queues: checks flagged documents, submits to universities, records decisions, answers chat
Admissions head	A region, or global	Same, plus sees workload, reassigns, releases on-hold applications, overrides a status with a reason
IP team	Global	Signs up and sets up universities; pauses or ends them
Data team	Global	Keeps course data right; approves changes the bots can't publish safely
Commissions and Finance	Global	Sets commission rules, fixes exceptions, approves payouts
Super admin	Global	Users, roles, regions, settings

How work is routed

- Every agency belongs to one **sales region**, based on its country. At go-live there are 13: India, Bangladesh, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Vietnam, IMT (Indonesia, Malaysia, Thailand), Myanmar and Bhutan, Australia, Philippines, Africa, Latin America and Europe, and Pakistan.
- The region decides which Admissions team, BDM and recruitment head look after the agency. Work never moves between regions.

- A new application goes to the region's Admissions queue and is given to the next person in turn. That person handles it to the end and is shown to the agency as its **GSP contact**.
- A **queue** is just the list of records whose status a role owns, sorted by deadline, then age, with a target time per item.

6. What we have to design

We are designing the full GSP 3.0 experience, for both agency users and GSP's internal teams, ready for go-live on 15 December 2026. A clickable prototype already exists, but its visual style is only a placeholder, so the real look, feel and flows are ours to design.

The work, in the brief's priority order

Priority	What it covers
1	University set-up (IP, university, campus, course), eligibility rules, documents-needed set-up, sales regions, queues, roles and permissions, data isolation, creating users, agency onboarding, course search
2	Student record, applications, commissions, email automation, StudyLink integration, enquiries
3	Outside connections: wallet, WhatsApp, StudyLink

The screens this means (my view)

- **For agencies:** Home with a "Needs you" list, Applications (list and detail with status, documents, chat and activity), Students, Find courses (search, compare, shortlist), Earnings, Profile, and the sign-up and onboarding flow.
- **For GSP teams:** My queues for Admissions, agency review for BAP, university and course set-up for the IP team, held course changes for the Data team, commission exceptions for Finance, and user and region settings for Super admin.

The design rules the brief sets

1. **Every screen answers "What do I do now?"** Lead with the summary and the next action; detail is one click away.
2. **The layout never changes with the status.** Tabs and sections stay in the same place; only their content changes. An empty section says so plainly ("Nothing to do. You'll see it here and on WhatsApp when something is needed").
3. **Chat is a full-width area,** not a small box beside other content.
4. **Always show who has it,** in colour and words: amber for the agency, violet for GSP, blue for the university.
5. **Keep it minimal for agencies.** No internal statuses, staff checks, rules or jargon (say "entry requirements", never "assessment criteria"). If a field doesn't change what the agency does next, it isn't on their screen.
6. **Warn, don't block.** Only hard rules stop an action, and every warning explains itself.
7. **Every automatic step is visible** in the activity log, with who or what did it.
8. **Learn from competitors.** Already reviewed: ApplyBoard and CourseFinder (course pages, eligibility), Crizac (student record, application history, full-width chat), KC Overseas and CourseFinder (agency home, application lists), Leverage (activity and updates).

What we start from

- The clickable prototype (GSP Partner Portal), where "Viewing as" switches between agency and GSP logins. Agency test logins: Ananya (Horizon Overseas, India) and Lan (Saigon Bridge, Vietnam) as admins; Vikram (Horizon Pune) and Minh (Saigon Bridge Hanoi) as branch admins; Rahul (Horizon Lucknow) as a counsellor.
- The upGrad brand guidelines.

7. The features

The brief describes the features GSP 3.0 must have, and the prototype already shows them working. It does not describe the old live system, so the features below are the planned ones. Several already use AI or automation, marked **(AI)**.

Course search and eligibility (agency)

- Results show once five things are known: destination, the student's country, their state or province, study level and area. Picking a student fills these in; a plain-language box ("mba uk under 22k jan") can fill the rest **(AI)**.
- Courses the student can't apply to are hidden automatically. A university that has blocked this agency never appears.
- Filters, a course card (fees, deposit, IELTS, intakes with "closes in N days", "You earn", eligibility with its reason, "Checked 30 Sep" to show data freshness), and sorting by best match.
- **Priority** tag for universities the IP team wants to push for certain countries; they show first.
- **Student view:** one switch hides all earnings so the counsellor can share the screen with the student.
- Compare up to 5 courses, download a branded shortlist PDF with the agency's logo, or apply straight from the card.
- **One eligibility check used everywhere** with four answers: Eligible, Eligible with conditions, Not eligible, Add details to check. It warns but never blocks, and always says why ("Academics 58%, needs 57% for India").

Documents (agency and GSP)

- Documents live in three places: the agency's own proof, the student's documents (kept once, reused), and what each application needs at each stage.
- One set of statuses everywhere: Missing → Uploaded → Checking → Verified, or Flagged → Rejected. Seven fixed reasons for sending one back.
- Upload one file and the system warns if it looks wrong ("This looks like an IELTS result, not a passport") **(AI)**.
- Drop many files at once and the system names each one; unclear ones must be sorted before saving **(AI)**.
- Uploading the passport fills in name, date of birth, gender, nationality, number and expiry **(AI)**.
- Automatic checks (passport code, English score lookup, name and date matching, tamper check) raise flags; Admissions only looks at the flags **(AI)**.
- An application can't go to Pre-Screening while a must-have document is missing; the button says what's missing.

Chat and notifications

- One chat per application, per agency and per university. Email replies land in the same thread.
- **An AI assistant answers first** from the application's status, history and rules. It never changes data, and hands over to a person when it can't answer, or for money, exceptions and complaints. Target: 9 in 10 questions answered by AI, and a human reply within 2 working hours **(AI)**.
- A general "Ask GSP" assistant on every agency screen **(AI)**.
- When GSP asks for a document in chat, it becomes a tracked request that is ticked off on upload.
- Notifications: in-app bell and "Needs you" list, plus WhatsApp in India, Bangladesh, Nepal, Sri Lanka and Vietnam (email elsewhere). Sent only to the person who must act, with quiet hours, a daily cap and a digest option.

Internal automation (GSP)

- **Agreement reading:** AI drafts university records from the signed agreement; people confirm only unsure fields **(AI)**.
- **Course bots** keep course data up to date; the Data team approves risky changes like fee jumps or new campuses **(AI)**.
- **Email engine:** reads university emails, attaches them to the right application and moves the status ("Conditional offer received"). Unplaced emails go to an "Emails to action" queue with its top three guesses **(AI)**.
- **Commission engine:** calculates both commission lines and the weekly statements, so nobody raises a claim.
- **Queues and routing:** round-robin assignment by region, sorted by deadline, with target times.

8. The current problems

The brief doesn't list today's problems directly, but each part of GSP 3.0 is clearly fixing one. The first table reads them back from the brief; the second is **my view** of the risks for our design.

Problems the brief is solving

Problem today	Who feels it	How the brief tackles it
Agencies don't know where an application is or who has it, so they phone and email to chase	Agencies, Admissions	One owner per status, shown in colour and plain words; chat inside the application
Documents are the biggest chore and the top reason applications stall; a wrong file can cost a week	Agencies, Admissions	Upload once, reuse; AI catches wrong files at upload
Too much manual checking for a small team handling about 50,000 applications a year	Admissions	Automatic checks; people handle only flagged exceptions
University replies arrive in shared email inboxes and someone has to place each one	Admissions	Email engine places most emails and moves the status
Agencies see internal statuses, rules and jargon that don't help them act	Agencies	Minimal agency screens; plain words only
Agencies can't easily see what they will earn, and may have to raise claims	Agencies, Finance	Earnings view, tier progress, self-billed statements
Setting up a university from its agreement is slow, manual typing	IP team	AI reads the agreement and drafts the records
Course data (fees, intakes) goes out of date	Agencies, Data team	Bots keep it fresh; "Checked on" date on each course
Agencies apply to courses the student can't get into	Agencies, Admissions	One eligibility check everywhere, with reasons

Risks and open questions for design (my view)

- **We haven't seen the old system or its users yet.** The problems above are inferred. We should confirm them with real agencies and Admissions staff before we design.
- **Two systems for a while.** GSP 3.0 is for every *new* application from 15 December. It's unclear how agencies will see applications still running in the old system.

- **Trust in AI.** If AI reads documents and emails, people need to see the evidence and be able to correct it, or they will check everything by hand again.
- **Many roles, one design.** Twelve roles share one layout; the GSP side could easily become dense and inconsistent.
- **Wording by country.** The same eight stages need different words per destination (CoE, CAS, I-20, LOA), which must stay clear.
- **Device and language.** It's not stated whether counsellors work mostly on phones, or whether non-English screens are needed (e.g. Vietnam).

9. Feature and solution suggestions (my view)

These go beyond the brief. Each one aims to cut manual work or answer one of the three agency questions faster. They are ideas to test, not decisions.

For agencies

1. **Act from the "Needs you" list.** Upload a document, pay a deposit or confirm a condition straight from the list, without opening the application.
2. **"What happens next, and by when".** Under each status, show the next step and a typical wait based on that university's past speed ("Usually 10 to 14 days").
3. **Student readiness meter.** One bar per student showing which documents are done, and which applications are waiting on each missing one.
4. **Earnings forecast.** Money expected by stage, plus a tier bar ("3 more enrolments to reach 75%").
5. **"Near miss" alternatives.** When a student isn't eligible, suggest similar courses they *do* qualify for, or say what would fix it ("IELTS 6.5 needed").
6. **Share with the student.** Send the shortlist on WhatsApp, or a link where the student uploads their own documents.
7. **Smooth handover.** When a counsellor leaves, the branch admin moves all their students to someone else in one step.

For GSP teams

1. **One summary card per application.** AI lists what passed and what's flagged, with the evidence side by side ("Name differs: passport vs transcript").
2. **Side-by-side checking.** For agreements and documents, show the original file next to what AI read, with the unsure fields highlighted.

3. **Suggested replies.** When the chat assistant hands over, a draft reply is ready for Admissions to edit and send.
4. **At-risk alerts.** Flag applications likely to miss a deadline, and agencies going quiet, before they become a problem.
5. **Workload view.** Admissions heads see each person's queue, target times and overdue items at a glance.

More AI ideas

- **Offer letter reader:** turn a conditional offer's conditions into a checklist for the agency.
- **Expiry watch:** warn if a passport or English test will expire before the course or visa date.
- **Chat translation:** let agencies chat in their own language (for example Vietnamese) while Admissions reads English.
- **Visa funds check:** compare bank statements against the destination's money rules before the visa is lodged.

A good next step: walk the prototype as each role, then talk to a few agencies and Admissions staff to confirm the problems in section 8.

10. Glossary

Term	Meaning, simply
GSP	upGrad Global Study Partners: the business and the platform
RP	Recruitment partner: a local agency that finds and helps students
MP	Master Partner: a bigger agency that holds smaller ones and is paid for them
IP	Institution partner: who GSP signs the commission agreement with (one university, a group, or an aggregator)
University / institution	Where the student studies; belongs to one IP

Term	Meaning, simply
BDM	Business development manager: GSP's sales contact for an agency
BAP	The GSP team that checks and activates new agencies
Sales region	The market an agency belongs to; decides which GSP teams handle it
Queue	The list of records waiting on a role in its region
Primary / additional application	The student's first choice, and backups that start only if it fails
Intake	A course start date (e.g. Feb 2027)
Census date	The date after which a student counts as enrolled for commission
Entry requirements	What a course needs from a student (never "assessment criteria" on agency screens)
Conditional / unconditional offer	An offer with conditions still to meet / a final offer
GS	Genuine Student assessment (Australia)
CoE, CAS, I-20, LOA	The enrolment document a student needs for the visa: Australia, UK, USA, Canada
StudyLink	A system many Australian and NZ universities use to receive applications
Tier	A commission rate that rises with the number of enrolments (e.g. 70%, 75%, 80%)
Self-billed statement	The commission statement GSP makes on the agency's behalf, so it never raises an invoice

11. The whole journey, step by step

The full order runs from a university going live to the agency being paid, in 20 steps. A university must be set up first, because only live universities appear in course search. Agency sign-up is a separate track and can happen at any time.

The last column says whether we need to design for that step: **Yes** means new screens or a flow; **Light** means only a status or a small element on an existing screen. The screens named are my view of what each step needs.

University goes live

Step	What happens (who)	UI to design?
1	GSP agrees terms with the institution partner; the agreement is signed (IP team)	**Yes.** Institution partner list and record, with its status (Negotiating, Set-up, Active, Renewal due, Ended)
2	The agreement is uploaded; AI drafts the records; people confirm unsure fields (IP team, AI)	**Yes.** Upload screen, and a review screen showing the agreement beside the AI's fields, unsure ones highlighted
3	Three checklists run side by side: commission rules; profile, campuses, who can apply, how to submit; courses (Finance, IP team, bots and Data team)	**Yes.** A set-up checklist per team, plus the Data team's "Held changes" queue
4	The university becomes Active and its courses show in search (system)	**Light.** Status change on the university record

Agency joins

Step	What happens (who)	UI to design?
5	The agency signs up with one short form and an email code; it can search courses and add its team and branches (agency admin)	**Yes.** Sign-up form, email code, first landing, team and branch invites
6	The agency uploads proof of its business; after 3 days without it, the BDM is asked to call (agency admin, BDM)	**Yes.** Document upload in Profile, and the BDM's stuck-agency alert
7	BAP checks the documents: send back, approve or reject; approved agencies are Activated (BAP)	**Yes.** BAP's "Waiting for BAP" queue and review screen; the agency's view of what to fix

Step	What happens (who)	UI to design?
8	The agency signs the agreement and can earn commission (agency admin)	**Yes.** Agreement view and sign step; Earnings unlocks

Application

Step	What happens (who)	UI to design?
9	The counsellor adds a student; the passport fills personal details, or the student fills it by link (counsellor, student)	**Yes.** Student record, document upload with passport autofill, student self-fill link
10	The counsellor finds a course: search, eligibility, compare, shortlist (counsellor)	**Yes.** Find courses: search, filters, course card, eligibility, compare, shortlist PDF, Student view switch
11	**New:** the counsellor applies and uploads what the course needs; it can't move on while a must-have document is missing (counsellor)	**Yes.** Apply flow, document checklist, and a blocked button that names what's missing
12	**Pre-Screening:** automatic checks run; Admissions reviews only the flags (system, Admissions)	**Yes.** Admissions "Flagged documents" queue with evidence; the agency's re-upload request with its reason
13	**Application:** Admissions submits to the university and saves its reference (Admissions)	**Yes.** "Check and submit" queue and submit step
14	**Offer:** the university decides; its reply is placed by the email engine or StudyLink (university, system)	**Yes.** "Emails to action" and "Decisions to record" queues; the agency's status and offer letter
15	**Verification:** the agency sends the conditions, GSP checks finances, the university assesses (agency, GSP, university)	**Yes.** Conditions checklist for the agency; "Verification exceptions" queue for GSP
16	**Acceptance:** the student pays the deposit; the university issues the CoE, CAS, I-20 or LOA (agency, university)	**Yes.** Deposit receipt upload and enrolment document status

Step	What happens (who)	UI to design?
17	**Visa:** the agency lodges the visa; the government decides (agency, government)	**Light.** Lodgement receipt upload and visa status

Commission

Step	What happens (who)	UI to design?
18	**Enrolled:** census date passes; the system works out what the university owes; Finance approves the invoice; the university pays (system, Finance, university)	**Yes.** Finance invoice approval and "Exceptions" queue; the agency sees Expected, then Confirmed and Invoiced
19	The system works out the agency's share and pays it with a weekly self-billed statement (system, Finance)	**Yes.** Agency Earnings: lines, statements, payments; Finance payout approval
20	At year end, tier top-ups are paid on both sides (system, Finance)	**Light.** Tier progress and top-up lines in Earnings

At any step from 11 to 17 the application can end early (Withdrawn, Deferred, Rejected, Refused, Not eligible or Did not join). If the primary application fails, the student's additional applications start. Separately, 60 days before a university's agreement ends, it comes up for renewal.